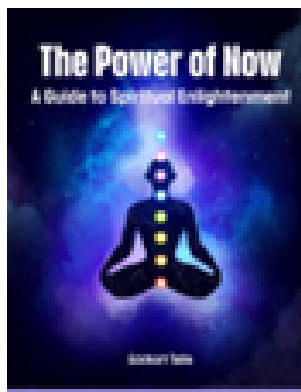




THE POWER OF NOW

A Guide to Spiritual Enlightenment

ECKHART TOLLE



The Big "So What"



This book is a spiritual self-help guide to help us discover our true Being, release our pain and find deep inner peace. When we are intensely present in the Now, we respond from deep consciousness and flow with ease and joy in life. In so doing, we can better fulfill our outer purpose (to achieve goals and seek to create a better world), while fulfilling our inner purpose and truly changing the world at cause.



Introduction

Tolle started the book by sharing the circumstances and experiences leading to his "enlightenment". Like many others, he had suffered from anxiety and even suicidal depression for many years. Then, when he was 29 years old, he had a personal epiphany which brought him "a state of the most intense joy", and changed the course of his life since.

Tolle only fully understood his transformation years later, and this book acts as a spiritual self-help guide to capture what he has discovered through his experience and years of spiritual study. The book is organized in a Q&A format, addressing common questions about spiritual enlightenment. We have organized some of the key ideas and exercises in this summary into 5 main segments.

Tolle reminds us not to be attached to specific words or images used in the book, as they are simply a means to help awaken the spiritual truth that already lies in all of us. Likewise, [we recommend that you focus on the essence beyond the words or images used in our summary, and to focus instead on essence of Tolle's messages.](#)

KEY QUOTES

"True wealth...is the radiant joy of Being and the deep, unshakable peace that comes with it."

"I am not teaching you. You are consciousness, and you are listening to yourself."

"I cannot tell you any spiritual truth that deep within you don't know already. All I can do is remind you of what you have forgotten."



You Are Not Your Mind

One key idea in the book is this—at the core, we are pure consciousness, beings of love, joy and peace. Yet, most of us are struggling and in pain because we have unknowingly “identified with our mind” and a false sense of self.

Enlightenment simply means regaining awareness of our true Being and being deeply connected with Being.



Our Egoic Mind

We use our mind for countless purposes, from learning a language to conceiving a new innovation. The mind also holds perceptions, beliefs, attachments, and as a result, a range of physical and emotional forms.

The mind is a powerful tool, when used properly. **The problem is, most of us don't consciously use our mind; instead, we are controlled by our minds:**

 **Incessant mental noise.** If you see someone on the street talking incessantly to himself, you would probably consider him crazy. Yet, we talk to ourselves all the time—complaining, comparing, judging, commenting, speculating, voicing likes and dislikes...The only difference is, we do it silently in our minds. **Most of us do not have an “off” switch to turn off the incessant mental noise,** and our minds keep running, unchecked and uncontrolled.

 **False sense of identity.** Because we are not in conscious control of our mind, most of us aren't even aware of the thoughts, beliefs, and perceptions that are being created in our heads. In fact, we often become so fully identified with the external identity conceived by our mind, that we lose touch with our true inner “Being”.

Let's pause for a quick exercise: Take a minute to ask yourself this question: “Who am I and what do I stand for?”. Do your answers involve your possessions, job title, social status, education, abilities, relationships, beliefs, religion and even family history?

KEY QUOTES

“All things that truly matter - beauty, love, creativity, joy, inner peace - arise from beyond the mind.”

“Being can be felt, but it can never be understood mentally.”

“Ego is the unobserved mind that runs our life when you are not present as the witnessing consciousness, the watcher.”

“The mind...is a wonderful tool. Dysfunction sets in when you seek your self in it and mistake it for who you are. It then becomes the egoic mind and takes over your life.”

Do you realize that most of these things you identify with are merely collective identifications in your mind derived from external sources? They are not you, and they will not follow you beyond your death. Tolle refers to this as [our “ego” or our derived sense of self](#).

Enlightenment: rising above thought



Because the ego is not your true self, it can only exist by drawing on external sources. It feeds on the past (who you think you are, based on past experiences, memories etc.) and the future (who you think you want to be, based on beliefs and perceptions drawn from external influences). [So long as you identify with your mind \(and the ego-self that it presents\), it will remain your biggest obstacle to enlightenment.](#)

In fact, we can become addicted to thinking, because we become so identified with our thoughts, memories, and the associated false sense of self, that we unconsciously fear to stop thinking.

[Enlightenment means “rising above thought”. In your enlightened state, you’ll still use your mind. The difference is, you can lay it aside and quieten your mind when you choose to](#), i.e. you use your mind, but are not enslaved to it.

[Try this exercise:](#) Close your eyes and say to yourself, “I wonder what my next thought is going to be”. Then, just wait for the next thought to emerge, like a cat watching a mouse-hole with full alertness. Take a minute to try it now.

You will probably find that you just entered a state of intense presence, when you are free from thought, yet are fully alert.



The Illusion of Time and the Power of Now

Stop the delusion of time



Like your ego, time is a concept created by the human mind, to help us function in the practical world. “Clock time” is useful for tasks like scheduling appointments and running a meeting, as well as to learn from the past and set goals for the future.

However, [time is really an illusion](#). Imagine for a moment if

KEY QUOTES

“Death is a stripping away of all that is not you. The secret of life is to ‘die before you die’ – and find that there is no death.”

“Enlightenment means rising above thought...you still use your thinking mind when needed, but in a much more focused and effective way than before.”

“When you are intensely present, you don’t need to be concerned with the cessation of thinking... the mind... stops automatically.”

“Nothing ever happened in the past; it happened in the Now. Nothing will ever happen in the future; it will happen in the Now.”

there are no human beings on this planet –if you were to ask the tree or the bird “what time is it?”, your question won’t make any sense, because to them, [the time at this moment is simply “now”](#).

Indeed, everything that has ever happened or has been created happened in the Now. It is the only moment that we ever truly possess.

- At this moment, the past is only memory traces in your mind. It is over and does not determine who you are now.
- At this moment, the future is just an illusion or an anticipation in your mind. It does not yet exist and does not determine who you are now.

In fact, when you are remembering the past, you are doing it now. Whatever you are creating for the future, you are creating now. [So, the most precious moment is Now, because that's the only time you really have, and it is also the only point that can free you from your mind](#) (which we will touch on later).

Unfortunately, your mind can only perceive time in the past and future. Hence, [the only way you can understand the power of now is to know and feel it with your Inner Being](#).

The Power of Now



Most of us are trapped in the illusion of time. We spend the bulk of our energy reminiscing the past, or hoping for a better future. In the process, we are absent in the “Now” - the only real moment that we have. Worse still, we create pain in the present when we unconsciously resist what is, either through judgment and/ or negativity.

[All negativity and suffering come from “psychological time” that we create](#). Feelings of guilt, regret, sadness etc. come when we dwell too much in the past. Feelings of worry, anxiety, stress etc. come when we dwell too much in the future.

We may believe that our past and feelings like fear help to warn us against potential danger. Tolle points out that the physiological state of [fear arises from worry or anxiety that something might happen in the future](#). This “anxiety gap” arises because we are in the now, but our mind is in the future.

KEY QUOTES

“The moment you grasp it, there is a shift in consciousness from mind to Being, from time to presence. Suddenly, everything feels alive, radiates energy, emanates Being.”

“If it is the quality of your consciousness at this moment that determines the future, then what is it that determine the quality of your consciousness? Your degree of presence.”

“Realize deeply that the present moment is all you ever have. Make the Now the primary focus of your life.”

Ask yourself: "What, at this very moment, is lacking?". If you focus on Now - not 5 minutes, 1 year or 10 years from now-you will probably realize that there is no problem, pain nor suffering. You are truly free of problems when you are in the Now.

The key to enlightenment is to stop creating psychological time by dwelling in the pain of the past or the pain of the future. Focus on the Now, and say "yes" to life at the present moment, so it can start working for you.



Accessing the power of Now

Free yourself from the mind



To free yourself of your mind, you need to learn to observe it impartially. Constantly ask yourself "what is going on inside me at this moment?" and "am I at ease at this moment?"



Watch the thinker. The first step is to become aware of the voice in your head – realize that you are not your mind; you're merely an observer of your mind. Listen to your own thoughts, and be especially attentive to any repetitive thought patterns that emerge. When you listen, do it impartially, without judgment or condemnation. When you can observe your thoughts, you will no longer be controlled by them unconsciously.



Watch your emotions. Your emotions are a reflection of what's on your mind. Since we can't observe every single thought, we can use emotions as a tool to bring awareness to our thoughts, including the sub-conscious ones. Watch your emotions without judgement. Do not dwell on the situation, person or event that you perceive to have caused the reaction, as that will only energize the emotion and thought pattern behind it.

When you can allow the emotion to be there without feeling controlled by it, you'll no longer be the emotion. You'll merely be the observer of the emotion.



Dissolve the pain-body. Our past experiences (including our experiences as a child or even past lives) can leave behind residues of pain, like an accumulated "negative energy field". This "pain-body" carries all the stories, baggage and external identities that our egoic mind creates.

KEY QUOTES

"In the Now, in the absence of time, all your problems dissolve. Suffering needs time; it cannot survive in the Now."

"Be at least as interested in what goes on inside you as what happens outside. If you get the inside right, the outside will fall into place."

"Make it a habit to ask yourself: What's going on inside of me at this moment... Don't analyze, just watch."

"When you listen to a thought, you are aware not only of the thought but also of yourself as the witness of the thought. A new dimension of consciousness has come in."

"Whenever you are able to observe your mind, you are no longer trapped in it."

Similar to your thoughts and emotions, you can watch your "pain-body" when it awakens or emerges, taking the form of anger, irritation, depression etc. So long as you unconsciously fear facing the pain in your life, you are identifying with your pain-body and sustaining it. [When you become present and conscious of your pain-body, you can start to break identification with it; it can no longer draw strength through you.](#)

If you realize that you are not feeling good about something, either

- a) Stop doing what you are doing;
- b) Speak to the person concerned; or
- c) Decide to drop the negativity that your mind has created around the situation, like how you would drop a hot coal.

[When you observe that you have negative emotions or reactions, start by accepting it \(not judging or condemning it\).](#) Realize that the ability to observe your emotions is already a step forward. When you have practiced acceptance of your emotions long enough, you will eventually stop creating them.

Enlightenment: rising above thought



 [Stop "Creating Time".](#) Learn to withdraw attention from the past and future when it's not needed. After you have used "clock time" to set your goal, taken the necessary action steps with full attention, and handled other practical activities, withdraw attention from them. Do not continue to depend on those goals for fulfillment, happiness or even self-identity. That way, you do not create and build up "psychological time", unconsciously identify with the past, nor compulsively project into the future.

Instead, focus on the Now. Even if your present moment seems unpleasant or undesirable, start by becoming aware of how your mind is labeling your present situation, and accept it as if you had chosen it. Then, take action from there.

 [Be Present and Act with "Present-Moment Awareness".](#) Learn to direct your focus fully into the present moment, such that you are alert, aware but not thinking. For example, when doing any routine activity (be it walking up the stairs, washing your hands), become intensely conscious of the activity itself, feeling

KEY QUOTES

"Whenever you are able to observe your mind, you are no longer trapped in it."

"Instead of quoting the Buddha, be the Buddha, be 'the awakened one'."

"When consciousness frees itself from its identification with physical and mental forms, it becomes what we may call pure or enlightened consciousness, or presence."

"Without judgement, without resistance to what is, (negative emotions) would not arise."

"There is nothing wrong with setting goals and striving to achieve things. The mistake lies in using it as a substitute for feeling of life, for Being."

"Whatever the present moment contains, accept it as if you had chosen it. Always work with it, not against it. Make it your friend and ally, not your enemy."

and sensing every breath and moment, without thinking about it.

During life-threatening situations (e.g. a fire or accident), we'll react intuitively and incisively. Our minds have no time to create a problem out of the situation, we're forced into the **Now**, and we respond out of consciousness. That's why we hear stories of people who show amazing capabilities during life-and-death situations—not because of their fear, but because they are acting from “present-moment-awareness”.

When you are Being, you will find joy, ease and lightness in what you are doing. This means that, even when you are pursuing external goals, you will no longer depend on them to make you happy or to “save” you. You will no longer pursue them with fear, stress, discontent, or a psychological need. **The “how” of what you are doing – acting out of present-moment awareness - is hence more important than the result you want to achieve.**

 **Accept and surrender to what is.** If you are genuinely unable to change your present situation, and you can't even remove yourself from the situation, then “surrender” to it by accepting what is. “Surrender” does not mean weakness, giving up or being fatalistic. It simply means that you drop all inner resistance to what is.

If you realize that at this present moment, your life is already perfect, you should be feeling joyous and peaceful, even as you take action to improve your life situation. Or, you may even find that the situation has changed without any effort on your part. In any case, you are free.

Don't wait



If you are waiting for something in your life to happen before you will be happy, bring yourself back to the Now. If you have been waiting for prosperity, stop waiting. True prosperity is feeling grateful for your life now as it is; when you have that state of mind, you are already prosperous now and prosperity will manifest for you in other ways over time.

KEY QUOTES

“Ultimately, this is not about solving your problems. It's about realizing that there are no problems. Only situations – to be dealt with now, or to be left alone and accepted as part of the ‘isness’ of the present moment.”

“As soon as you honor the present moment, all unhappiness and struggle dissolve, and life begins to flow with joy and ease.”

“Do not be concerned with the fruit of your action – just give attention to the action itself. The fruit will come of its own accord.”

“Surrender is the simple but profound wisdom of yielding to rather than opposing the flow of life.”

“Gratitude for the present moment and the fullness of life now is true prosperity.”

Find the Life under your life situation.



We sometimes feel overwhelmed by our present life situation. This arises mainly because we are still caught in psychological time of the past and future. We are resisting what happened in the past and/ or what is. We hope that the future will be better, but that, too, takes our focus away from the present. The key here is to stop focusing on our life situation, and to instead focus on our life, now, at this moment. **Realize that there are no problems in the Now, only situations that you can deal with or accept.**

Contemplation of space and silence



Being is something that cannot be explained with words, nor understood by the mind. It is like how you cannot explain water to a fish—it can only be felt or experienced.

Space and silence are similar in that, they are essentially no-thing. Yet, there can be no sound without silence, and there can be no form without space. **When you become aware of silence, space and "nothingness" in your external world, you'd have achieved stillness within, and experienced a shift in consciousness inside you.**

So, to develop greater awareness:

- Rather than listen to the sounds around you, pay more attention to the silence, becoming aware of the silence between and underneath the words and sounds.
- Rather than pay attention to the things around you, focus on the space or "nothingness" in which they exist.



The Inner Body and Self-Healing

Awareness of the Inner Body



As you develop a deep awareness and connection with your InnerBody or your Being, you will realize that you are not isolated in your physical form, but one with the rest of the Universe.

Try these exercises to connect with your Inner Body.

KEY QUOTES

"What could be more futile, more insane, than to create inner resistance to something that already is?"

"Paying attention to outer silence creates inner silence: the mind becomes still."

"Silence without, stillness within. You have entered the Unmanifested."

"Space and silence are two aspects of the same thing, the same no-thing. They are an externalization of inner space and inner silence, which is stillness; the infinitely creative womb of all existence."

"The inner body lies at the threshold between your form identity and your essence identity, your true nature. Never lose touch with it."

- [Feel your body from within](#). Close your eyes and direct your attention into your body. Feel the life in each part of your body, pausing for 15 minutes as you focus on your feet, legs, hands, arms, stomach, chest... If it helps, visualize each part of your body, your cells and organs, becoming luminous as you focus on it. Feel the energy, become aware of it, but don't think about it.
- [Use conscious breathing](#). Follow your breath as it moves in and out of your body, focusing on how it fills and flows through your body.

Initially, you may need to use these exercises above to help you connect with your Inner Body. However, when you can feel your inner body easily as one field of energy, try to let go of the visual images and only focus on the feeling itself. Use meditation to go deeper into your body. [Eventually, focus so deeply into that feeling that you merge with the inner energy field and are one with it.](#)

When you feel and know that your inner and outer bodies are as one, you have effectively transcended your body and connected with the Source.

Inhabit your Body and Stay Rooted Within



As a spiritual practice, learn to retain some energy for your internal connections (rather than focus fully on the external world). Stay deeply connected and rooted with your Inner Body.



[Stay connected](#). When you are doing something (e.g. reading, working), do it with your entire body, feeling rooted and connected within. When you are waiting (e.g. in traffic or queues), take the time to go deeper into the Now and your Inner Body.



[Think with your whole body](#). When you need a solution or a creative idea, don't just think with your mind. Think with your whole body, by shifting your attention inward to your inner energy field. Be still for a moment, as if you are listening internally, and allow your responses to come from a deeper, more conscious level.



[Listen with your whole body](#). When listening to others, listen with your entire body and not just your mind. Feel your inner energy field, and through that, the other person's Being. This

KEY QUOTES

"Transformation is through the body, not away from it."

"When you reach a point of absolute stillness, which is nevertheless vibrant with life, you have gone beyond the inner body and beyond chi to the Source itself."

"By going deeply into the body, you have transcended the body."

is how you listen in a "space of no-mind", without constant mind interference.

Self-healing



The more you "inhabit" your body, or bring consciousness into the body, the more your entire body seems to come alive. Although your outer, physical body will age and fade with time, your inner body doesn't change. When you're present and connected with the timeless Inner Body, you raise your vibrational frequency, improve your natural self-healing capability, slow down the aging process, and strengthen your immune system.

➡ **Fill your body with consciousness and boost your immune system using this self-healing meditation.** Lie down and close your eyes, slowly "scanning" your body and focusing (say, for 15 seconds each) on various parts of your body. Feel the energy in each cell. Do this whenever you are unoccupied, especially just before falling asleep or first thing when you wake up in the morning.

⌚ **Remove time from illness.** Illness needs a past and a future to take root. **In the Now, there is no illness, only physical pain, weakness etc.** Do not label your physical discomfort as an illness. Instead, surrender fully to the Now, where illness (like other problems) cannot exist.

🕊 **Before you enter the body, Forgive.** Often, we have not accepted or forgiven certain people, events or conditions in the past, present or even the future. Before you enter your body, check for emotions or "grievance patterns" like resentment, blame, self-pity etc. **When you realize that your pain serves no purpose, and are ready to release your resistance to life, and life can truly live through you.**

KEY QUOTES

"You cannot feel someone else's Being except through your own. This is the beginning of the realization of oneness, which is love."

"If the master is not present in the house, all kinds of shady characters will take up residence there. When you inhabit your body, it will be hard for unwanted guests to enter."

"Forgiveness is to offer no resistance to life to allow life to live through you."

"The mind cannot forgive. Only you can... The moment you truly forgive, you have reclaimed your power from the mind."



The Inner Body and Self-Healing

So far, everything we've discussed are all ways for you to de-identify with your mind, and discover/ connect with your inner Body, including an intense presence in the Now, stillness, cessation of thinking, contemplation of space and time, surrendering etc. These are all "portals" into the UnManifested, Source or God. When the portal is open, love comes through into this world.

As you go deeper into your Being and become permanently connected, you become a bridge between the Source and the external world. This is enlightenment.

Enlightened Relationships



Emotions are generally subject to duality, because they are derived from something outside of you. However, [there are 3 states-love, joy and peace-which are a part of your inner connectedness](#). Hence, they have no opposites, and can never be lost.

According to Tolle, true love is not selective nor exclusive, since it is part of our natural Being. However, there may be one person who reflects your love back to you more clearly and intensely (and vice versa) and you are hence in a love relationship.



[Duality in "love"](#). Most relationships oscillate between states of being "in-love" and conflict or dissatisfaction. In such cases, the "love" arises from the mind and ego-attachment, and it comes with "clinginess" and a sense of incompleteness. When the ego needs are temporarily met, you feel "in love"; but when your partner no longer meets these needs, your pain-body lashes out. [Recognize that true love doesn't cause pain or unhappiness; you are merely experiencing the pain and unhappiness that's already in you.](#)



[To move from addictive to enlightened relationships](#), you'll need to stop judging yourself, then stop judging your partner. [When you can accept your partner completely as who he/she is, with no need to judge nor change him/her in any way, then you have transcended your ego self.](#) You can now reflect back to each other the love that you feel deep within. This is true love, one that has no opposite.



[Use your relationship as part of your spiritual practice](#). Similar to how you watch your thoughts and emotions, [become an observer of your relationship and your partner's behaviors, doing so without judgment or expectation.](#)

Inner Peace and the Cycle of Life



It is possible to feel deep inner peace regardless of circumstances:

KEY QUOTES

"Love, joy and peace are deep states of Being or rather three aspects of the state of inner connectedness with Being. As such, they have no opposite."

"Love is a state of Being. Your love is not outside; it is deep within you. You can never lose it, and it cannot leave you."

"Your task is not to search for love but to find a portal through which love can enter."

"You certainly cannot transform your partner or anybody else. All you can do is create a space for transformation to happen, for grace and love to enter."



It is what it is. In many self-help books, we are taught that if we only hold positive thinking and attitudes, we will manifest only positive events and situations. Tolle suggests that, **from a higher perspective, there are no positive or negative conditions. Things are simply "as they are";** it is only in our minds that they are labeled "good" or "bad". Obviously, when someone close to us passes away, we'll find it hard to feel happy. However, beyond happiness and unhappiness, we can be at peace. Learn to forgive each moment, and allow it to be as it is, so you do not accumulate new unhappiness to be forgiven in the future. If you can accept the Now while taking action to improve the future, you will enjoy peace underneath your happiness or unhappiness.



Accept impermanence. Nature moves in cycles, such as morning and night, birth and death. **Up and down cycles of success are inevitable, and it's not true that the up-cycle is good and the down-cycle is bad.** In fact, the down-cycle is essential for spiritual growth, because deep loss or pain are typically what drives us to the spiritual dimension. When you label a condition as "good", your mind becomes attached to it, and you feel a fear of loss or sadness when the cycle ends. Happiness derived from such sources is not lasting nor deep. Instead, **when you accept the cyclical nature of life while relishing the present, you'll find true inner peace.**



The next time you observe yourself having a negative reaction, imagine that you have become transparent to that external cause of the reaction. **Let it go right pass you, and let it "disappear."**

Shift in Planetary Consciousness



In our lives, we have our outer purpose (arriving at a goal or destination), and our inner purpose (deepening of our Being). **Many of us seek to create a better world, when what we should be doing is to awaken from our own identification with form.** Only when there is a mass shift in planetary consciousness can we truly and literally inhabit a new world. We get to salvation and enlightenment by realizing that we are there already there, and by accessing the power of Now.

KEY QUOTES

"Happiness depends on conditions being perceived as positive, inner peace does not."

"Forgiveness of the present is even more important than forgiveness of the past. If you forgive every moment...then there will be no accumulation of resentment that needs to be forgiven at some later time."

"Your happiness and unhappiness are in fact one. Only the illusion of time separates them."

"Only those who have transcended the world can bring about a better world."

So, become aware of your mind-including thoughts, feelings, pain-body-and accept them as part of what is, without analysis nor judgment. When you de-identify with your mind, you can access your true inner Being. When you surrender and accept the Now, you flow with rather than resist life. [When there are enough people bringing light and consciousness to the world, it will naturally change – at cause.](#)

In this state, you are more conscious, can see clearly what must be done, and can tackle it one thing at a time, without unnecessarily worrying about the future. You respond from deep consciousness to get more effective results. You bring more love into this world.

If you can find someone who is intensely conscious, being with them and joining them in the state of presence can help you to strengthen your light and increase your consciousness.



Other Details in the Book to Look out For

The ideas in the book may seem simple at first glance, but there are many nuances and insights that can only be gleaned by experiencing the spiritual truths behind the words. Tolle presents them using various angles and perspectives in the Q&A format. Although Tolle isn't identified with any specific religion, he has been influenced by a wide range of spiritual works, and he makes many references to God, Christ, Jesus and Buddha in this book, using these terms interchangeably with words like "presence", "Source", and the "Unmanifested".

If you resonate with the ideas in the book, we strongly recommend that you read the entire book to personally feel and experience Tolle's message.

KEY QUOTES

"Become an alchemist. Transmute base metal into gold, suffering into consciousness, disaster into enlightenment."

"The world is only a reflection... If you accept the image (in the mirror), no matter what it is, if you become friendly toward it, it cannot not become friendly toward you. This is how you change the world."

"Until you are able to experience what I speak of, you may find those passages somewhat repetitive. As you do, however, I believe you will realize that they contain a great deal of spiritual power, and they may become for you the most rewarding parts of the book."